3 The Owls in the Family

Warm up

Match the types of owls to their pictures.

great horned owl | barnyard owl | snowy owl | spotted owl

1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____ 4. _____

Let's read what happened when two baby owlets landed on the veranda steps of the narrator's bungalow.

One morning, we found a full-fledged baby spotted owlet on the ground by the veranda steps. When Grandfather picked it up, it hissed and clacked its bill, but after a meal of raw meat and water, settled down for the day under my bed.

Do you think the owlet was happy or scared when Grandfather first picked it up?

The spotted owlet, even when full grown, is only the size of a myna, and has none of the threatening appearance of the larger owls. A pair of them may often be found in an old mango or tamarind tree, and by tapping on the tree trunk, you may be able to persuade the bird to show an enquiring face at the entrance to its hole.

The bird is not normally afraid of man, nor is it strictly a night-bird; but it prefers to stay at home during the day, as it is sometimes attacked by other birds, who consider all owls as their enemies.

Why does the author use the word 'enquiring' for the owl's face?

veranda: balcony full-fledged: completely developed clacked: made a short, loud sound bill: beak myna: a kind of bird with dark feathers threatening: expressing a danger of harm or violence persuade: convince somebody to do something

The little owlet was quite happy under my bed. The following day, a second owlet was found in almost the same place on the veranda, and only then did we realize that where the rainwater pipe emerged through the roof, there was a rough sort of nest, from which the birds had fallen. We took the second young owl to join the first, and fed them both. When I went to bed, they were on the ledge just inside the mosquito netting, and later in the night, their mother found them there. From outside, she crooned and gurgled for a long time, and in the morning, I found that she had left a mouse with its tail tucked through the mosquito net! Obviously, she did not trust us to look after them.

What did the mother owl do that made the narrator think that she did not trust him and his grandfather to look after the baby owls?

The young birds grew well and, ten days later at dawn, Grandfather and I took them into the garden to release them. I had placed one on a branch of the mango tree, and was stooping to pick up the other, when I received quite a heavy blow on the back of my head. A second or two later, the mother owl swooped down at Grandfather, but he was agile enough to duck out of its way. Quickly, I placed the second owl under the mango tree. Then, from a safe distance, we watched the mother fly down and lead her young ones into the long grass at the edge of the garden.

We thought she would take her family away from the surroundings of our rather strange household; but next morning, on coming out of my room, I found two young owls standing on the wall just outside the door! I ran to tell Grandfather, and when we came back, we found the mother sitting on the birdbath ten yards away. I got the feeling that she was sorry for her behaviour the previous day, because she greeted us with a soft 'whoo-whoo'.

emerged: appeared crooned: made a low sound like humming gurgled: made a contented sound
stooping: bending down blow: a hard hit swooped: quickly flew downwards in order to attack
agile: able to move quickly and easily duck: move one's head or body downwards to avoid being hit by something birdbath: a bowl filled with water for birds to wash in and drink from

"Now there's an unselfish mother for you!" said Grandfather. "It's obvious she'd like them to have a good home. And they're probably getting a bit too big for her to manage."

So, the two owlets became regular members of our household, and strangely enough, were among the few pets that Grandmother took a liking to. In fact, the owls became so attached to Grandmother that they began to show affection towards anyone in a petticoat, including Aunt Mabel, who was terrified of them. She would run shrieking from the room every time one of the birds went close to her in a friendly manner.

In response to Grandmother's voice, the owlets would make sounds as gentle and soothing as the purring of a cat; but when wild owls were around, ours would disturb the night with terrible shrieks. Their nightly occupation was catching beetles, with which the kitchen quarters were infested at the time. With their sharp eyes and powerful beaks, they were excellent pest destroyers.

List six sounds of an owl that the narrator has mentioned in the text.

The owls loved to sit and splash in a shallow dish, especially if cold water was poured over them from a jug at the same time. They would get thoroughly wet, jump out on to a perch, shake themselves, then return for a second splash and sometimes a third.

Looking back on those owlish days, I carry in my mind a picture of Grandmother with a contented look in her rocking chair. Once, on entering her room while she was having an afternoon nap, I saw that one of the owls had crawled up her pillow till its head was snuggled under her ear. Both Grandmother and the little owl were snoring.

petticoat: a thin piece of cloth worn under a dress or skirt infested: full of (here) beetles pest: unwanted insects or small animals perch: a place where a bird rests snuggled: settled into a warm, comfortable position

Ruskin Bond (born in 1934) is a beloved Indian author of British descent who was born in Kasauli, Himachal Pradesh. He has written several short stories, essays and children's books. He wrote his first novel *The Room on the Roof* when he was merely 17 years old. *The Blue Umbrella* and *Rusty, the Boy from the Hills* are some of his most popular works.

In this section, we will:
- remember details about the story.
- infer and interpret the main ideas of the story.

(C-2.1, C-2.2)

Make connections

Map the story

Answer the following questions based on the story.

1. Based on your understanding of the story, state whether the following sentences are true or false.
   a. The spotted owlet is the largest owl species.
   b. Spotted owlets and mynas are friends.
   c. Spotted owlets live in holes on trees.
   d. Spotted owlets are nocturnal birds—they are active only at night.
   e. Spotted owlets eat other small animals.
   f. Spotted owlets have sharp eyes.
   g. Spotted owlets have weak beaks.
   h. Spotted owlets enjoy getting wet.
2. The term character is used for a person who appears in a story, book, play or a movie. Name the characters mentioned in the story 'The Owls in the Family'.

Deep dive

Answer the following questions with reference to context.

1. *I had placed one on a branch of the mango tree, and was stooping to pick up the other, when I received quite a heavy blow on the back of my head.*

RECALL	INFER	ANALYSE
a. Where was the narrator and what was he stooping to pick up?	b. Why did the owl give the narrator a blow on his head? Contrast this with the behaviour of the owl as the story progresses.	c. Have you ever witnessed or read any news about an animal attack? Briefly describe the incident and discuss possible reasons that might have led to the attack.

2. *So, the two owlets became regular members of our household, and strangely enough, were among the few pets that Grandmother took a liking to.*

RECALL	INFER	ANALYSE
a. Who were the members of the household besides Grandmother?	b. Did all members of the narrator's household like the owlets? How do you know?	c. Why do you think Grandmother developed a soft spot for the owlets?

Read, reflect and write

1. The setting of a story describes where and when the story takes place. What details of the setting does the writer give us?
2. When a person narrates a story about something that happened to them, it is called a personal narrative. What makes this story a personal narrative?
3. Did the narrator and his grandfather treat animals with respect? Give reasons for your answer.

Integrate

Draw up an A to Z chart of birds. You can include names of birds or words associated with them. For example: For 'F', you could write 'flamingo' as well as 'flightless'.

Did you know?

There are around 10,000 different species of birds around the globe. Among them, the chicken is the most common species.

Word wall

Compound words

In this section, we will:
- combine two different words to create compound words.
- rearrange letters to form anagrams.
- identify the antonyms of given words.

(C-4.2)

Compound words are words made up of two or more existing words.

Examples:					
	bird	+	bath	=	birdbath
	rain	+	water	=	rainwater
	house	+	hold	=	household
	after	+	noon	=	afternoon
	grand	+	mother	=	grandmother

Match the columns to get compound words that are names of insects, birds or animals.

1.	earth	a.	hopper
2.	rattle	b.	gull
3.	dragon	c.	pecker
4.	grass	d.	fish
5.	sea	e.	bird
6.	humming	f.	worm
7.	jelly	g.	fly
8.	wood	h.	snake

Anagrams

An anagram is a word formed by rearranging the letters of another word.

Examples: below → elbow dusty → study listen → silent

Form words related to birds by rearranging the letters of the words given below.

a. sent b. bake c. rooters d. greet

e. wolf f. honer g. raptor h. low

Antonyms

Write the antonyms of the following words.

a. raw b. later c. release d. stooping

e. broad f. occupied g. terrified h. shallow

Grammar time

In this section, we will:
- revise and practise tenses by using the correct form of the verb. (C-34)

Revision of tenses

Read the given sentences.

- Grandmother and the little owl were snoring. (action)
- Aunt Mabel is terrified of the owls. (state)

In the sentences given above, *were snoring* and *is terrified* are verbs.

A verb expresses an action or a state.

A verb has different forms:
- base form (I eat).
- base form + *-s* (He eats.)
- *-ing* form (I am eating.)
- past participle form (I have eaten.)
- past form (I ate.)

Read the given sentences.

- An owl flies at night.
- An owl is flying about.
- An owl flew by my window.
- An owl was flying here last night.
- An owl will fly around tonight too.
- An owl will be flying around our house at midnight.

In each of these sentences, the verb *fly* is in a different form or tense.

ANCHOR CHART

TENSES

verb forms that show the time of actions

	Simple	Continuous
Past	**Simple Past** actions that have **already happened** + I played chess. − He did not play chess. ? Did you play chess?	**Past continuous** an action that **was happening** at some time in the past + I was playing chess. − He was not playing chess. ? Were you playing chess?
Present	**Simple present** **everyday actions** and **routines**; **general truths** + I play chess. − He does not play chess. ? Do you play chess?	**Present continuous** an action that **is happening at the time of speaking** + I am playing chess. − He is not playing chess. ? Are you playing chess?
Future	**Simple future** an action that has **not yet happened** + I will play chess. − He will not play chess. ? Will you play chess?	**Future continuous** an action that **will be happening in the future** + I will be playing chess. I am going to play chess. − He will not be playing chess. He is not going to play chess. ? Will you be playing chess? Are you going to play chess?

1. Fill in the blanks with the most suitable form of the verbs given in brackets. One has been done for you.

Radhika reads (read) a lot.
She _____ (love) mystery and adventure books. Her favourite book _____ (be) *The Swiss Family Robinson.*

Sujoy and Pranav _____ (read) a lot too. All three of them _____ (read) right now in the school library.

Last year, Radhika _____ (read) over fifty adventure and mystery stories. On her last birthday, when it was time to cut the cake, Radhika was not to be found. Everybody _____ (look) for her. Finally, her mother _____ (find) her. She _____ (sit) under a tree in the garden and reading!

Next week, Radhika, Sujoy and Pranav _____ (go) to the public library in New Delhi. Kirti _____ (drive) them. At this time next week, they _____ (travel) to the city.

2. Rewrite these sentences using not correctly. You may have to make some other changes in the sentences.

a. Maria does swim not every day.
b. He not was wasting his time.
c. Malcolm ate not all the cookies.
d. The students not went on a field trip.
e. My grandmother not is working right now.

3. Write a question for each of these answers. One has been done for you.

a. Yes, they play every day.
Do they play every day?

b. Yes, she is driving the tractor.
c. Yes, they will be planting saplings.
d. No, the students don't waste water.
e. No, the children will not watch the television.

Irregular verbs

To create the simple past or past participle form of a regular verb, we usually add *-d* or *-ed*. Irregular verbs do not follow this usual pattern, but they can be divided into different groups based on their similarities.

In each group in the table below, cross out the row that is not completely correct.

Group types	Base form	Simple past	Past participle
Group 1 All three forms are the same	cut put shut get	cut put shut get	cut put shut get
Group 2 Simple past and past participle forms are the same	lose meet bite teach	lost met bit taught	lost met bit taught
Group 3 All three forms are different	built drive forget wake	builded drove forgot woke	built driven forgotten woken

Spellings

In this section, we will:
- learn to spell words ending with /v/ sound. (C-3.4)

-ve words

Read the given sentences.

- Aunt Mabel drove the car in the evening.
- Grandmother gave the owls a snack to eat.

Words that end with the /v/ sound, as in *drove* and *gave*, always have the letter 'e' after the letter 'v'. The letter 'e' always follows 'v' at the end of the word unless the word is an abbreviation, an acronym or a name.

Examples: alive stove brave

List five other words that end with the /v/ sound and the letters 've'.

_____ _____ _____ _____ _____

In this section, we will:
- learn to compare and contrast two or more objects using signal words. (C-3.1, C-3.2, C-3.3)

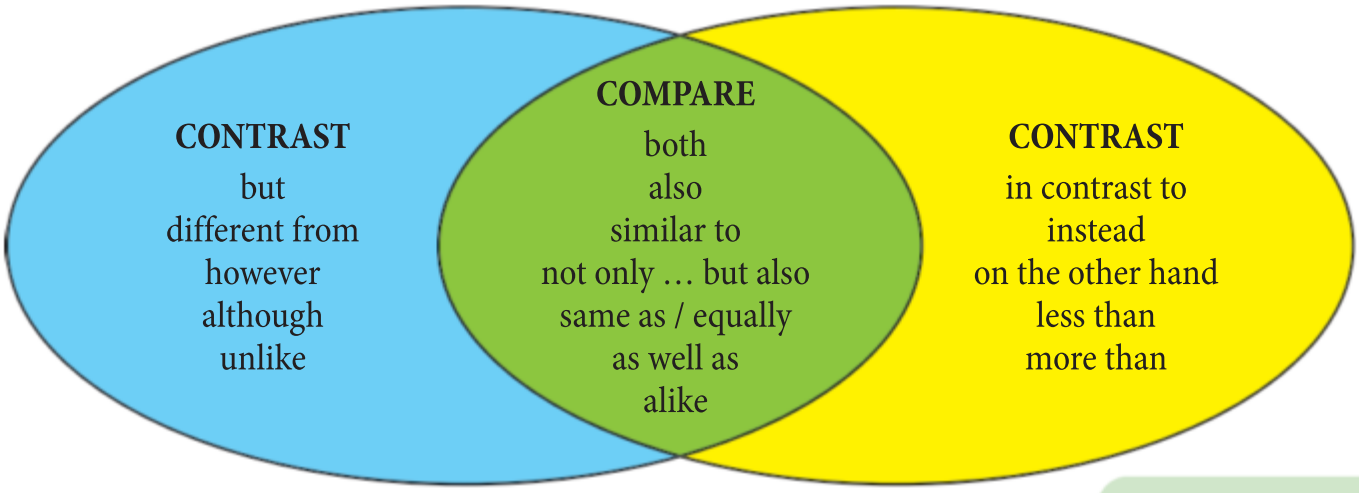
Write well

Signal words: compare and contrast

Signal words show how two or more things are alike or different.

Example: Both the cities, Jaipur and Udaipur, are known for their historic forts and palaces.

Compare and contrast any two birds of your choice. Include information about their appearance (such as beaks and claws/feet), food, habitat, unique abilities and fun facts. Use the signal words given in the diagram to plan your writing.



In this section, we will:
- listen carefully and locate specific details.
- learn to agree or disagree using suitable expressions. (C-1.1, C-1.3, C-2.2)

Listen and speak well

1. **Listen carefully to Grandfather telling the narrator about some endangered animals. Circle the animals he describes.**

a. i.

ii.

iii.

b. i.

ii.

iii.

c. i.

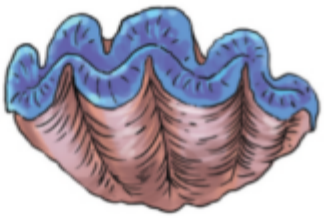
ii.

iii.

d. i.

ii.

iii.



2. Read the topics given below and discuss them with your partner. Take turns to speak for or against a topic. Use the expressions given in the table to agree or disagree with each other.

a. One should not keep exotic pets.

b. Humans are more intelligent than other animals.

c. Animals should not be domesticated, they should be left to roam freely in the wild.

d. Loss of habitat is the biggest reason for the extinction of animals.

Agreeing

That's right!
Definitely! Absolutely!
That's a good point.
Yes, I agree!
I couldn't agree more!

Partly agreeing

I see your point, but ...
Maybe, but don't you think ...
That's partly true, but ...
I agree up to a point, but ...
That's true, but ...

Disagreeing

I'm sorry but I don't agree.
That's not right.
I totally disagree.
Absolutely not!
I'm afraid I disagree ...